Unified Silla Kingdom

Historians generally believe that the Unified Silla Kingdom (668 - 935 CE) was the earliest dynasty to have dominion over this region. In the northern part of the country there was a state known as Balhae or Parhae, which existed at the time. However, majority of its land was located in Manchuria so many scholars do not acknowledge it as a state of Korea.

The Unified Silla Kingdom was then separated into nine provinces and five minor capital cities. Kumsong, or better known as Sorabol at the time, remained as the main capital and experienced a major renovation project. Numerous buildings and structures were constructed including palaces, temples and pagodas. Nearly one million people lived in the city when it was at its peak.

The central government reorganized the local administrative system all the way down to the little villages. The ruling families, their extended families and troublemakers were forced to relocate elsewhere. Furthermore, the sons of village leaders were forced to send their first male children to work in the capital's administration buildings or within the army. There were significant advances in the agricultural sector due to sophisticated irrigation planning. A series of trading networks were mapped throughout the East Asian region. Because of this and a lack of warfare, the arts and science fields experienced considerable growth during this time.

From the eighth century onwards, the Unified Silla Kingdom began to decline slowly. The decline was mostly due its strict class status, which was still being determined by the bone ranking system. Ideas were scarce and inspiration was low because there was a distinct lack of social movement. The elite class became increasingly resentful of the king's power. The peasants already had a negative view of the upper class because they felt they were being exploited by heavy taxes. Furthermore, people from the landed aristocratic class were rioting so much that the government could not keep them in line.